

Learn HTML

Lesson 3: Lists and Links

Lists and Links – Study Notes

Key Concepts

1. **Ordered ()** vs. **unordered ()** lists – how browsers render numbered and bulleted items.
2. **List items ()** – the required child element for both and .
3. **Nesting lists** – placing a list inside another list to create sub levels.
4. **Hyperlinks ()** – the anchor element used to link to other pages, sections, or external resources.
5. **Link attributes** – target, rel, and title for controlling link behavior and accessibility.

Summary

HTML provides two fundamental list structures: ordered lists () for sequences where the order matters (e.g., steps in a recipe) and unordered lists () for collections where the order is irrelevant (e.g., a shopping list). Each list is built from one or more (list item) elements. Lists can be nested to any depth, allowing you to represent hierarchical information such as outlines or menus.

Links are created with the <a> (anchor) element. The href attribute holds the URL or fragment identifier of the destination. When a user clicks the link, the browser navigates to that address. Optional attributes like target="_blank" open the link in a new tab, while rel="noopener" improves security for external links. Combining lists and links is common for navigation menus, tables of contents, and resource lists.

Important Points

- **** automatically numbers items; you can change the numbering style with the type attribute or CSS list-style-type.
- **** displays bullet points; the bullet shape can also be altered with CSS.
- Every list **must** contain elements; stray text inside / is invalid.
- **Nesting**: place a new or inside an to create sub lists.
- **<a> basics**: link text – the link text is what users click.
- **Relative vs. absolute URLs**:
 - Relative (href="about.html") points to a file in the same site.
 - Absolute (href="https://example.com") points to an external site.
- **target="_blank"** opens in a new tab/window; always pair with rel="noopener noreferrer" for security.
- **Accessibility**: provide meaningful link text; avoid "click here". Use title attribute sparingly for extra context.

Examples

1. Ordered & Unordered Lists with Links

```
```html
<h2>My Favorite Websites</h2>

 <a href="https://developer.mozilla.org" target="_blank"
 rel="noopener noreferrer">MDN Web Docs
 <a href="https://stackoverflow.com" target="_blank"
 rel="noopener noreferrer">Stack Overflow

 Personal Projects

 Portfolio Site
 Tech Blog


```
```

Explanation:

- The outer ``<ol>`` numbers the main items.
- The third item contains a nested ``<ul>`` for sub links, showing how lists can be combined.
- Each ``<a>`` uses ``href`` for the destination and ``target="_blank"`` with ``rel`` for safe external navigation.

2. Navigation Menu (Unordered List of Links)

```
```html
<nav>

 Home
 About Us
 Services
 Contact

</nav>
```
```

Explanation:

- A ``<nav>`` element semantically groups navigation links.
- An unordered list provides a clean, bullet free menu (bullets are usually removed with CSS).
- Each list item contains a single anchor linking to a page within the same site.

Quick Review

1. **What HTML elements are required to create an ordered list?**
2. **How do you make a link open in a new browser tab safely?**
3. **Describe how to nest a list inside another list.**
4. **When should you use a relative URL versus an absolute URL in the `href` attribute?**
5. **What is the purpose of the `rel="noopener noreferrer"` attribute on external links?**

Further Reading

- **HTML `<nav>` element** – semantic navigation structures.
- **CSS `list-style-type` & `list-style-image`** – customizing bullet and numbering appearance.
- **ARIA roles for lists and links** – improving accessibility for screen readers.
- **HTML5 `<section>` and `<article>`** – organizing content beyond simple lists.
- **Security considerations for external links** – deeper dive into `rel` values and referrer policies.

